

Pager Rotation in DevOps How Teams Actually Handle On Call

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Why On Call Exists

someone has to notice when stuff breaks at night that's what on call is for there's always somebody ready to jump on it or hand it off to whoever can actually fix it usually that's the person who wrote the code in the first place end goal is customers never even notice something went down

How Rotations Get Structured

small teams usually just swap days or do it weekly since anything shorter burns people out fast bigger teams spread across time zones go with follow the sun instead so it's always someone whos actually awake handling things some places also keep a backup person on standby just in case

Making Shifts Sustainable

most shifts run 8 to 12 hours smaller teams or ones getting hit with a ton of alerts usually stick to 8 hour shifts to keep burnout down longer 12 hour shifts mean fewer handoffs which matters since that's usually where stuff slips through the cracks managers should also be part of the rotation not just checking in from the outside

Avoiding Burnout

reliability and how the team is actually doing need to go hand in hand not compete with each other putting time into docs and automation early on saves a lot of headaches down the line and people should get paid fairly for carrying the pager since its real work not something you just quietly absorb teams that handle this well end up keeping their people a lot longer

Let Automation Handle It

spreadsheets work fine for small teams but fall apart the second things scale up a better setup is having one person on point with a backup right behind them so nothing slips through if a page goes unanswered for a few minutes it should just auto forward to the next person none of this needs to be complicated it just needs to run on its own without someone babysitting it

Sources

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